

A Reference Grammar of Borlish

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Conventions and Abbreviations

Notation

Borlish forms are given in italics, as in *Borallesc*. Letters and spellings are given between angle brackets, as in <ç>; phonemic transcriptions between slashes, as in /sbøk/; and phonetic transcriptions between square brackets, as in [zbøk]. Obsolete forms and senses are marked with a dagger[†]. Unless otherwise stated, phonetic transcriptions reflect the mesolectal speech of Damvath.

Examples

Numbered examples give the Borlish form, its phonemic transcription (and, where relevant, its phonetic transcription), and a gloss. Glosses follow the Leipzig Glossing Rules: a hyphen separates affixes, an equals sign separates clitics, and a full stop joins several glosses that correspond to a single form. Grammatical categories are given in small capitals, using the abbreviations below. A category is glossed only where it is marked by a difference in form: the bare stem of a verb is glossed by its meaning alone, and a pronoun is glossed obl only where its oblique form differs from its subject form. For clarity, however, pronouns in disjunctive use are always glossed dsj, and third-person singular pronouns used as objects are always glossed acc.

Glossing abbreviations

1 first person

2	second person
3	third person
acc	accusative
agt	agentive
comp	complementizer
cop	copula
def	definite
dist	distal
dsj	disjunctive
f	feminine
fut	future
indf	indefinite
inf	infinitive
ipfv	imperfective
m	masculine
n	neuter
neg	negative
obl	oblique
pl	plural
poss	possessive
prox	proximal
prs	present
pst	past
ptcp	participle
q	question particle
refl	reflexive
sbjv	subjunctive
sg	singular

Part I

Introduction

Chapter 1

Introduction and Context

Borlish is a Romance language, the primary language spoken on the island of Borland. It is the only surviving member of the Insular Romance languages.

Throughout this reference we will use ‘Borlish’ to refer to the standard variety of the language, which is based on the educated speech of the capital Damvath.

Chapter 2

Word Classes

[To be written.]

Part II

Sounds and Writing

Chapter 3

Phonology

3.1 Phonemes

Consonants

Borlish has a consonant inventory of middling size. Notable is the presence of /ʒ/ without its voiceless counterpart /ʃ/, due to a relatively recent sound change which backed the latter to /x/.

Consonants							
m			n				
p b			t d		k g		
			ts				
f v	θ ð	s z	ʒ	x	h		
w ¹		l	j	r ²			

¹In native vocabulary the phoneme /w/ appears only after /k/. This, along with alternations like

- (1) *voc* *voccar* | *bocq* *bocquar*
 /vɔk vɔ'kar | bɔk bɔ'kwar/
 †summons to summon | fee to charge

have led some to analyse /kw/ sequences as a single phoneme /k^w/ which merges with /k/ in coda position.

² The rhotic is uvular, but for ease we will denote it by /r/ in phonemic transcription.

Vowels

Borlish has eight monophthong vowel phonemes, typical of neighbouring Germanic and sister Gallo-Romance languages.

Vowels		
i	ɪ	u
e		o
ɛ	a	ɔ

Borlish also contains the diphthong /au/, as well as vowel + /j/ sequences that may be analysed as diphthongs.

The segments /m n r/ can appear as syllabic consonants.

- (2) *batesm* *cohernt* *outrscac*
 /ba'tɛz.m ko'hɛr.ɳt ,ut.r'xak/
 baptism consequent brazen

The syllable preceding a syllabic consonant acts as a closed syllable, and the segment before a syllabic consonant acts as part of the coda of the previous syllable. Hence, it is usually considered most elegant to syllabify so that syllabic consonants have no onset.

3.2 Stress

The final syllable is usually stressed.

- (3) *scadom* *tatover*
 /xa'dɔm ,ta.to'ver/
 tomato potato

In words of four or more syllables, secondary stress is usually assigned in iambs, although anapaestic patterns do occur when the interior syllables are sufficiently light.

- (4) *deborsellar haubrjoraŋ*
 /de₁bɔr.sɛ¹lar₁ |hob.r.ʒo¹rants/
 pickpocket advertisement

There are some exceptions to final stress. Syllabic consonants reject stress onto the previous syllable. Moreover, the suffixes *-(e)nt* (forming present participles of *-r* conjugation verbs), *-(e)nç* (forming nouns from the same verbs) and *-essem*, *-errem* (forming comparatives) also enforce penultimate stress.

- (5) *casn pardenç pessem veðerrem*
 /'kazn₁ |'par.dents₁ |'pɛ.sɛm ve¹ðɛ.rɛm/
 oak loss worse elder

In many dialects these suffixes are parsimoniously analysed as instead containing syllabic consonants, pronounced as /-ɲt -ɲts -ɛs.ɱ -ɛr.ɱ/.

3.3 Phonotactics

There are several restrictions on where in a syllable or a word certain segments can appear. The consonants /v s ʒ h/ do not occur in coda position, and /ð/ does not occur word-finally. When morphology would place /ð s ʒ/ in a forbidden position they are replaced with /θ z x/ respectively.

- (6) *nað-ar nað | fass-ar fas | naj-ar nasçn*
 /na¹ðar₁ naθ | fa¹sar₁ faz | na¹ʒar₁ |nax.ɲ
 swim-inf swim | wrap-inf wrap | sail-inf sail.3pl

When morphology would place /v/ in a forbidden position, either /f/ replaces it or the preceding vowel is altered.

- (7) *cav-ir caf | bav-ar bau*
 /ka¹vɪr₁ kaf | ba¹var₁ bo/
 get-inf get | bark-inf bark

Syllabic consonants do not occur in stressed or initial syllables, and the ‘lax’ vowels /ɪ ɛ ɔ/ do not occur in stressed open syllables.

Onsets

Any vowel can begin an initial syllable, but under most analyses non-initial syllables must begin with a consonant.

- (8) *al enç aiç id eir onc aust ou*
 /al ents ets id ir ɔnk ost u/
 wing start ease ides go hook east egg

Any single consonant may constitute an onset. Two-consonant onsets are of three kinds: for the first, the second segment is a liquid (one of /l j r/; the case of /w/ is dealt with above), preceded either by a stop or a fricative. The liquid /l/ does not occur after the segments /t d θ ð ʒ/, and the liquid /r/ does not occur after the segments /ð s z ʒ/.

- (9) *plait droug gien thron*
 /plet druj ʒjɛn θrɔn/
 pleased contribution cheek throne

The second class of two-consonant onsets are a heterorganic stop followed by one of /s θ t d/; these usually derive from Greek.

- (10) *xyron chthonic ptyssoscia bdella*
 /ksi'rɔn kθɔ'nɪk ,pti.so'xja bde'la/
 scalpel subterranean glaucoma virus

The remaining two-consonant onsets comprise /s/ followed by a nasal, a stop, the two liquids /l j/ or the two fricatives /f v/.

- (11) *smout skore sdegn slanc siesc sforç svam*
 /smut sko're sdɪjn slank sjɛs sfɔrts svam/
 riot urgent scorn thin siege strain sponge

All the possible three-consonant onsets are formed by the combination of /s/ + consonant and consonant + liquid onsets.

- (12) *splorar spien sdruçol sfrey*
 /splo'rar spjɛn sdri'tsɔl sfri/
 explore hope lubrication horror

No more complex onsets are permitted.

Codas

Empty codas are permitted, including word-finally. However, the ‘lax’ vowels /ɪ ɛ ɔ/ do not occur in final open syllables (as these would necessarily be stressed).

- (13) *idone nijomm-au*
 /ɪ.do'ne ɲi.ʒɔ'mo/
 suitable bind-pst

Any single consonant except /v s ʒ h/ may be a coda. There are several types of two-consonant coda. A liquid may be followed by any non-liquid that can appear in codas at all; a nasal by any such non-liquid and non-nasal.

- (14) *sculd tragç corf lucern | hamt coyenç ans*
 /xɪld trɛjts kɔrf li'tsɛrn | hamt ko'jɛnts anz/
 obligation clue raven lantern | live prevention handle

The fricative /s/ may precede a voiceless stop; /f/ may precede /t/ specifically.

- (15) *cosp fest masq | haft*
 /kɔsp fɛst mask | haft/
 bee sting banquet disguise | busy

Conversely, /s/ may also follow any voiceless stop; after /t/ this is identical to the affricate phoneme /ts/.

- (16) *laps* *ouç* *jex*
 /laps uts ʒɛks/
 mistake silence bullseye

Finally among two-consonant codas, the cluster /kt/ is also permitted.

- (17) *abject*
 /ab'ʒɛkt/
 despicable

The few three-consonant codas that appear are a nasal or /j/ with a licit two-consonant cluster.

- (18) *boist* *deunx* *defonct*
 /bɔjst daunks de'fɔnkt/
 box near miss deceased

No more complex codas are permitted.

3.4 Allophony

Throughout this section, the phonetic transcription approximately reflects the mesolectal speech in the capital city of Damvath.

Assimilation

The phoneme /n/ is pronounced [ŋ] before velars.

- (19) *blanc* *viking* *mensc*
 /blank vi'king mɛnx/
 [blaŋk vi'kiŋg mɛŋx]
 white raid honour

Regressive voicing assimilation affects /s/ before any voiced obstruent, nasal or /l/.

- (20) *sboc svanið pasnagl desjeun bruslaç*
 /sbɔk sva'niθ pa'snejl dɛs'ʒaun bri'slats/
 [zbɔk zve'niθ pe'znejl dɪz'ʒaun bɾɪ'zlats]
 smirk unconscious parsnip breakfast sunburn

Palatals

The phoneme /x/ surfaces as [ç] when adjacent to a front vowel.

- (21) *scið esc*
 /xɪθ ɛx/
 [çiθ ɛç]
 possible bait

The phoneme /ʒ/, along with /j/ either word-initially or between an unstressed and a stressed vowel (in that order), is pronounced [j].

- (22) *jast yon çuyal*
 /ʒast jɔn tsa'jal/
 [jast jɔn tsɐ'jal]
 zinc where cicada

Non-rhoticity

Syllabic /r/ surfaces as [ɹ]. Furthermore, for some speakers syllabic /m n/ surface as [ɛm ɛn] respectively.

- (23) *issambr ðesmbal visn*
 /ɪ'samb.ɹ ðɛz.m'bal 'vɪz.ɹ/
 [ɪ'sam.bɐ ðɛ.zɛm'bal 'vi.zɛn]
 massacre dodgeball knot

Coda /r/ surfaces as length on a preceding monophthong, or as [ɹ] after a diphthong or /j/. The vowel's quality may also be altered, with /ar ir ur/ becoming [ɛ: ɪ: ʊ:] respectively.

- (24) *vert hagr tourm*
 /vɛrt 'hɛj.ɾ tɔrm/
 [vɛ:t 'hɛ.jɐ tɔ:m]
 green linchpin squadron

When a word beginning with a vowel immediately follows, the [ɾ] is resurrected as the onset of the next syllable.

- (25) *l'hour uncos*
 /lur ɪn'kɔz/
 [lɔː ɾɪŋ'kɔz]
 def = time something

Reduction

In syllables without primary or secondary stress, the vowel /a/ surfaces as [ɐ], the vowels /ɛ e i/ as [ɪ] and the vowels /ɔ o u/ as [ʊ].

- (26) *tovaresc taisson torvegl*
 /to.va'rex te'sɔn tɔr'viʝl/
 [to.vɐ'reɕ tɪ'sɔn tɔː'viʝl]
 homosexual badger whirlwind

Before an obstruent or after /n/, a coda /ts/ is pronounced [s].

- (27) *amaçgat fenç*
 /a.mats'gat fɛnts/
 [a.mɐs'gat fɛns]
 nursery split

The sequence /kts/ is realised as [ks].

- (28) *acceir facçon*
 /ak'tsir fak'tsɔn/
 [ɛk'sɪː fɛk'sɔn]
 approach party

Chapter 4

Orthography

4.1 The alphabet

The primary letters in the Borlish alphabet are ordered as in the table below.

Alphabet and Letter Names					
a	a	h	hac	q	cu
b	be	i	i	r	ar
c	ce	j	jot	s	es
ç	cedil	k	ka	t	te
d	de	l	el	u	iscon
ð	eð	m	em	v	ve
e	e	n	en	x	ex
f	ef	o	o	y	oy
g	ge	p	pe	z	zet

The character < w >, which is used in foreign words and some names (like *Willaum* ‘William’), is pronounced like < v > and called *vescon* ‘second-vee’. There are also some compound characters. The ligatures < æ œ >, primarily used in Classical loanwords, are called *æsc* and *æthel* respectively and pronounced as if written < e >. The character < ï > is referred to as *i jammel* ‘twin i’ and pronounced as if written < yi >.

In the following we will consider < y > to be a vowel when written between consonants and/or word boundaries, and a consonant otherwise.

4.2 Consonants

The following letters regularly denote a single phoneme.

b	/b/	m	/m/
ç	/ts/	n	/n/
d	/d/	p	/p/
f	/f/	q	/k/
j	/ʒ/	r	/r/
k	/k/	v	/v/
l	/l/	z	/z/

Of these, the letters < b d f l m n p r > may appear doubled, which usually does not affect their pronunciation.

- (29) *abbað joddy affis ollom commet bannir çoppin arrum*
 /a'baθ ʒɔ'di a'fɪz ɔ'lɔm kɔ'met ba'nɪr tsɔ'pɪn a'rɪm/
 abbot cuppa tip relic ban start toffee cosine

The only exception to this is that < mm nn rr > may denote a single consonant followed by a syllabic consonant. This is the reading when < mm nn rr > occurs word-finally or before a consonant.

- (30) *yem-m grin-n car-r*
 /'jɛm.m 'grɪn.n 'kɑr.r/
 get-1pl judge-3pl seek-inf

The letter < ð > is pronounced /θ/ word-finally and /ð/ otherwise.

- (31) *arð naðr ðeu*
 /arθ 'nað.r ðau/
 steep viper buttocks

The letter < x > regularly denotes the phoneme sequence /ks/.

- (32) *xivol euxon incox*
 /ksi'vɔl au'ksɔn in'kɔks/
 waltz quartz digestion

Consider the final six letters < c g h s t y > when they occur alone (not part of a digraph). In this case, the letters < t y > regularly denote /t j/ respectively. The letter < t > may be doubled, without any effect on its pronunciation.

- (33) *tien yoc* | *cattin*
 /tjɛn jɔk | ka'tɪn/
 yours husband | kitten

The letter < c > is pronounced /ts/ before < e i y > and /k/ otherwise. The doubled < cc > is pronounced /kts/ before < e i y > and /k/ otherwise.

- (34) *cigl cuivr bac* | *accaç occeir*
 /tsajl 'kajv.r bak | a'kats ɔk'tsir/
 darling copper twig | post kill

The letter < g > may be pronounced as either of /g ʒ/ before < e i y > and is pronounced /g/ otherwise. The doubled < gg > may be pronounced as either of /g gʒ/ before < e i y > and is pronounced /g/ otherwise.

- (35) *gevou genoil tenguð* | *suggesson*
 /ge'vu ʒe'nɔjl tɛn'giθ | ʒig.ʒɛ'sɔn/
 watch out knee bauble | suggestion

The letter < h > is either pronounced /h/ or is silent (the latter only in some vocabulary inherited from Latin and after vocalic < g >).

- (36) *heu hom agher*
 /hau ɔm o'jɛr/
 mien person tumbler

The letter < s > is pronounced /z/ in coda position or between vowels, and /s/ otherwise or when doubled.

- (37) *bevis* *bosaç* *bustr* | *bossir*
 /be'viz bo'zats 'bɪst.ɾ | bɔ'sɪr/
 banknote gunfire example | gentleman

Consonant digraphs

The six letters, < c g h s t y >, combine with other letters to form digraphs. The sequences < sc ch th > regularly denote the phonemes /x k θ/. The potentially ambiguous sequence < sch > is read /sk/.

- (38) *sclar* *chym* *thral* | *schol*
 /xlar kɪm θral | skɔl/
 lightning lymph slave | school

The sequence < cq > is pronounced /k/.

- (39) *jalicq* *jacquot*
 /ʒa'lik ʒa'kwɔt/
 waistcoat coat

The letters < g y > only form digraphs when combined with vowels, for which see below.

4.3 Vowels

Divide written vowels into two groups. Free vowels are either word-final or separated from the next vowel in the word by a single consonant letter (or one of < sc ch th >).

- (40) *choma* *epu* *idiocy* *nothe*
 /ko'ma e'pi ,i.djo'tsi no'θe/
 gnome express stupidity illegitimate

Checked vowels are either in a final closed syllable or separated from the next vowel in the word by at least two consonant letters.

- (41) *commun ambasc tour sincer*
 /kɔ'mɪn ˌam.bax'tʊr sɪn'tser/
 ordinary emissary genuine

First consider the letters < a e i o u y > when they occur alone (not part of a digraph). When they are free, < a e i o u y > are pronounced /a e i o i i/.

- (42) *cla vige bro cru try*
 /kla vi'ʒe bro kri tri/
 key wealthy dude raw turn

When they are checked, < a e i o u y > are pronounced /a ɛ ɪ ɔ ɪ ɪ/.

- (43) *vindron vampyr effus*
 /vɪn'drɔn vɒm'pɪr ɛ'fɪz/
 vintner vampire extensive

Between a consonant and one of the vowels < a e o u >, the letters < i u > denote the semivowel /j/. The letter < u > denotes the semivowel /w/ specifically after < q >.

- (44) *diac suet quelt*
 /djak sjet kwelt/
 mic familiar dinner

Vowel digraphs

The digraphs < au eu ou > are pronounced /o au u/ respectively. The rarer < ao eo > share their pronunciation with < eu >.

- | | | | |
|------|-----------------------|--|--------------------|
| (45) | <i>taur teun tout</i> | | <i>paon theory</i> |
| | /tor taun tut | | paun θau'ri/ |
| | bull scant everything | | peacock science |

The digraphs < ai ei oi ui > and < ay ey oy uy > are pronounced /e i ɔj aj/ respectively. Intervocally < y > does double duty, simultaneously affecting the previous vowel as stated and acting as an onset < j >.

- (46) *deit joivr | rayon huyaç*
 /dit 'ʒɔjv.r̥ | re'ʒɔn ha'jats/
 finger frost | sunbeam corruption

The vast majority of coda < g > and many other < g > before consonants form vowel digraphs. Here, the digraphs < ag eg ig og ug aug oug > are usually pronounced /ɛj ij aj ɔj aj oj uj/ respectively.

- (47) *bag deg rig pog tug faug voug*
 /bɛj dij raj pɔj taj foj vuj/
 berry ten queue few passion sickle wrong

However, there are exceptions where a < g > in one of the above environments is read consonantly.

- (48) *magr magr | migrar scigrar*
 /'mag.r̥ 'mɛj.r̥ | mɪ'grar xaj'rar/
 rash scarce | migrate redistrict

Chapter 5

Morphophonology

[To be written.]

Part III

Nominals

Chapter 6

Nouns and the Noun Phrase

[To be written.]

Chapter 7

Articles and Demonstratives

Borlish nouns are inflected neither for number nor for definiteness (Chapter 6). Both are instead expressed by the determiners that precede the noun: the definite article *y*, the indefinite article *un*, and the demonstratives *oc ec oç eç*, which double as the language's main means of marking number. This chapter also covers the quantifiers that occupy the same position before the noun. Possessive determiners are treated in Chapter 8 and numerals in Chapter 10, but their interaction with the article is described here.

In glosses, a preposition or possessive fused with the article is split into its parts: *ag* is glossed 'to.def', and *mell* '1sg.poss-def = '.

7.1 The definite article

Form

The definite article is *y* /i/ before a consonant, including a pronounced < h >. Before a vowel, a silent < h > (Section 4.2) or the semivowel < y >, it is elided to *l'* /l/, written joined to the following word.

- (49)
- | | | | | | | | | | |
|----------------|------------|--|----------|-----------------|--|--------------|--|-----------------|--|
| <i>y</i> | <i>mur</i> | | <i>y</i> | <i>hayennaç</i> | | <i>l'hom</i> | | <i>l'hostel</i> | |
| /i | mir | | i | he.je'nats | | lɔm | | lɔs'tɛl | |
| def | wall | | def | workload | | def = person | | def = hotel | |
| <i>l'yenç</i> | | | | | | | | | |
| <i>ljents/</i> | | | | | | | | | |
| def = arrival | | | | | | | | | |

Because *y* is pronounced as a vowel, a word with a separate form before vowels takes that form before the article. In particular, ‘and’ is *eð* rather than *e* before *y* (Chapter 17).

Contraction with prepositions

Three common prepositions fuse with *y* before a consonant: *a* ‘to, at’ gives *ag* /ɛj/, *de* ‘of, from’ gives *dy* /di/, and *ne* ‘in’ gives *ny* /ni/. Other prepositions stand apart from the article, as in *por y* ‘for the’, *sur y* ‘on the’ and *con y* ‘with the’.

Before a vowel, a larger but still closed set of prepositions fuse with *l*, giving the forms in *-ll*’ listed in the table below. The shape of the fused form is regular. A preposition ending in a vowel adds *-ll*’ (*de*, *dell*’); one ending in *-n* or *-r* replaces that consonant (*con*, *coll*’; *sur*, *sull*’); and one ending in syllabic *-r* adds *-ell*’ (*entr*, *entrell*’). Note the irregular *sou*, *soll*’. Which prepositions fuse is not predictable from their form, however. All others keep the article separate, including the vowel-final *parmy* ‘among’: *des l*’ ‘out of the, since the’, *vars l*’ ‘towards the’, *posc l*’, *tras l*’, *cas l*’, *durant l*’, *lonc l*’, *jusc l*’, *com l*’, *jos l*’, *ant l*’, *avant l*’, *doutr l*’, *parmy l*’.

Preposition and definite article			
		before a consonant	before a vowel
		<i>y</i>	<i>l</i> ’
<i>a</i>	‘to, at’	<i>ag</i>	<i>all</i> ’
<i>de</i>	‘of, from’	<i>dy</i>	<i>dell</i> ’
<i>ne</i>	‘in’	<i>ny</i>	<i>nell</i> ’
<i>con</i>	‘with’	<i>con y</i>	<i>coll</i> ’
<i>sur</i>	‘on’	<i>sur y</i>	<i>sull</i> ’
<i>par</i>	‘by, through’	<i>par y</i>	<i>pall</i> ’
<i>por</i>	‘for’	<i>por y</i>	<i>poll</i> ’
<i>pre</i>	‘before’	<i>pre y</i>	<i>prell</i> ’
<i>sou</i>	‘under’	<i>sou y</i>	<i>soll</i> ’
<i>entr</i>	‘between’	<i>entr y</i>	<i>entrell</i> ’
<i>contr</i>	‘against’	<i>contr y</i>	<i>contrell</i> ’
<i>deur</i>	‘away from’	<i>deur y</i>	<i>deull</i> ’

- (50) *Casc ivan nell'amaçgat reçoirn un bricot dy colluy*
 /kax i'van ne_lla.mats'gat re'tsoj.rɲ in bri'kɔt di ko'laj
 each child in.def = nursery get-pst.3pl indf gift of.def guild
indrec.
 in'drek/
 charitable

'Every child in the nursery received a gift from the charity.'

- (51) *Cal porra balanç intermanir ag tramou ny*
 /kal po'ra ba'lants in_lter.ma'nɪr ej tra'mu ni
 what can-fut recompense constitute-inf to.def shortfall in.def
porçonnement?
 ɸɔr.tsɔn'ment/
 allocation

'How will we make up for the budget shortfall?'

- (52) *Toð y cort ern connoscent de sy ligaçon*
 /tɔθ i kɔrt ɛrɲ ɸkɔ.no'xɛnt de si ɸli.ga'tsɔn
 all def court cop.ipfv-3pl know-prs.ptcp of 3sg.poss liaison
coll'aðm dy rey.
 kɔ'laðm di ri/
 with.def = mistress of.def king

'The whole court knew of his affair with the king's mistress.'

The contraction takes place only when the noun phrase is the complement of the preposition itself. When a preposition such as *a*, *de* or *por* introduces an infinitive clause, the object of the infinitive comes first (Chapter 18) and so may directly follow the preposition. The article then stays separate, both before a consonant (*a y*, not *ag*) and before a vowel (*a l'*, *por l'*, not *all'*, *poll'*).

- (53) *L'aye un pedisecq offiçað a y roum*
 /lɛ'je m ɲe.di'zɛk ɔ.fi'tsaθ a i rum
 3sg.m = have-ipfv indf goon set-pst.ptcp to def room
costojar.
 ɔ.ko.sto'ʒar/
 protect-inf

'He had set a lackey to guard the room.'

- (54) *Tu vel nos aiðar a l'ec fil cardonar ou?*
 /ti vel nɔz ɛj.i'ðar a lɛk fil ɔ.kar.do'nar u/
 2sg will.sbjv 1pl help-inf to def = prox.pl wire card-inf q

'Can you help us untangle these wires?'

The article with possessives and quantifiers

The possessive determiners *my*, *ty*, *sy*, *nossy*, *vossy* and *lorry* exclude the article before a consonant: *my fraðr* 'my brother', *sy ligaçon* 'his liaison'. Before a vowel, however, they fuse with *l'* just as prepositions do, giving *mell'*, *tell'*, *sell'*, *nossell'*, *vossell'* and *lorrell'*.

- (55) *Jo kigla reuvr a mell'orin pre*
 /ʒo kaj'la 'raw.vɾ a ɲɛ.lo'rɪn pre
 1sg fail-ipfv go.home-inf to 1sg.poss-def = homeland before
oc annað.
 ɔk a'naθ/
 prox.sg year

'I hadn't been back home until this year.'

The quantifier *toð* 'all, the whole' is likewise followed by the article, and fuses with it before a vowel as *toll'* (Section 7.4).

- (56) *Nos javigaum toð y majon livr por detaxion*
 /nɔz ʒa.vi'gom tɔθ i ma'ʒɔn 'li.vɾ pɔr ʔde.tak'sjɔn
 1pl trawl-pst-1pl all def house book for synthesis
cas aur.
kaz or/
 regarding gold

‘We searched the whole library for syntheses involving gold.’

Uses of the definite article

The definite article marks a noun phrase whose referent is identifiable. Because nouns do not inflect for number, a noun phrase with *y* may be singular or plural; its number is shown, if at all, by agreement on the verb.

- (57) *Y tissour aun un exeunt scenað.*
 /i ti'sur on in ɛk'sawnt xe'naθ/
 def weaver have.3pl indf walkout stage-pst.ptcp

‘The weavers have staged a walkout.’

- (58) *Yeðrot zajādau scanoirn y mur ne bric.*
 /jeð'rɔt ʒa.ʒa'do xa'nɔj.rɿ i mɪr ne bɾik/
 ivy variegated climb-pst.3pl def wall in brick

‘Variegated ivy grew up the brick walls.’

Generic statements normally use the bare noun. The article with the numeral *dou* ‘two’ gives *y dou* ‘both’, which may precede the noun like any determiner or follow the phrase it refers to.

- (59) *Tramou aun tagl eð asmuth y dou.*
 /tra'mu on teʒl ɛθ az'mɪθ i du/
 vector have.3pl length and direction def two

‘A vector has both size and direction.’

- (60) *Y dou tarnaç laundaurn ne sortir.*
 /i du tar'nats lon'dorŋ ne sɔr'tɪr/
 def two regular slip-pst-3pl in go.out-inf

‘The two regulars stumbled as they left.’

Personal names and the names of most countries, cities and islands take no article: *Istr Boral*, *Damvath*, *de Vascony* ‘of Vascony’, *n'Ambrosia* ‘in Ambrosia’. Several other kinds of name do take it:

- rivers and seas: *y Nil* ‘the Nile’, *y Sein* ‘the Seine’, *l'Orn* ‘the Orne’; *l'Atlantic*, *l'Adriaç* ‘the Adriatic’, *l'Austmar* ‘the Baltic’;
- heavenly bodies, compass regions and large regions: *y Tar* ‘the Earth’, *y Lun* ‘the Moon’, *y Sol* ‘the Sun’; *y Norð* ‘the North’, *l'Aust* ‘the East’; *y Novomond* ‘the Novomund’, *l'Arcabil*;
- historical periods, events and wars: *y Paç Lonc* ‘the Long Peace’, *y Rix Romannesc* ‘the Romantic Wars’, *l'Anarchy Portingal* ‘the Portingale Anarchy’;
- institutions, organisations, states and documents with descriptive names: *l'Empir Constant* ‘the Constant Empire’, *y Concert Norðer* ‘the Northern Concert’, *y Decret Sandrin* ‘the Sandrine Decree’;
- buildings, works of art and other named objects: *dy Majon Roug* ‘of the Red House’, *y Caðer* ‘the (Redstone) Chair’;
- ships: *l'Entrpris* ‘the Enterprise’;
- titles, and epithets after a name: *y Duc* ‘the Duke’, *Savino y Just* ‘Savino the Just’.

- (61) *Nos erau y Nil gaddant aval*
 /nɔz e'ro i nil ga'dant a'val/
 1pl cop.ipfv-1pl def Nile screw-prs.ptcp downstream
n'auror.
 no'rɔr/
 in = sunrise

‘We were motoring down the Nile at sunrise.’

- (62) *La passau y quoncein par y Novomond ađendrar.*
 /la pa'so i kwɔn'tsin par i ,no.vo'mɔnd ,a.đɛn'drar/
 3sg.f spend-pst def twenties by def Novomund tour-inf
 'She spent her twenties travelling the Americas.'

- (63) *Saveđ vos cal praxitel gravau y Macchine di*
 /sa'vɛθ vo kal ,prak.si'tɛl gra'vo i ,ma.ki'ne di
 know-2pl 2pl which sculptor carve-pst def Macchine di
Helio?
 he'ljo/
 Helio

'Do you know which sculptor carved the Machines of Helios?'

7.2 The indefinite article

The indefinite article is *un* /ɪn/, identical to the numeral 'one'. It has a single form, used before vowels and consonants alike (as in *un exeunt* 'a walkout' above).

It contracts with the same three prepositions as the definite article: *a* and *un* give *an* /an/, *de* and *un* give *d'un* /dɪn/, and *ne* and *un* give *n'un* /nɪn/. Other prepositions do not contract: *con un*, *par un*, *por un*, *pre un*.

- (64) *Jo vel hur dar an udomintel.*
 /ʒo vɛl hɪr dar an i.do.mɪn'tɛl/
 1sg will.sbjv hire give.inf to.indf babysitter

'I would like to hire a babysitter.'

- (65) *J'ay me caut orbeutað d'un*
 /ʒe me kot ˌor.baw'taθ dɪn
 1sg = have.1sg 1sg.obl get.pst.ptcp con-pst.ptcp of.indf
coroncr o'vart.
 ko'rɒnk o'vart/
 pretender open

‘I’ve been swindled by a blatant impostor.’

- (66) *Dou rout ranscellau n'un bosc gauvn.*
 /du rut ˌran.xɛ'lo nɪn bɒx 'go.vɪn/
 two road fork-pst in.indf wood yellow

‘Two roads diverged in a yellow wood.’

There is no plural indefinite article. Indefinite plurals and mass nouns appear either bare, as *yeðrot* ‘ivy’ above, or with the plural demonstrative *ec* (Section 7.3) or a quantifier such as *pieç* ‘some’ (Section 7.4). A specific indefinite, ‘a certain, a particular’, is expressed with *un certan*, as in *un certan volum* ‘a particular volume’. A noun that is non-specific, or stands for a kind rather than an individual, takes *untal* ‘such a, some such’ (Section 7.4).

7.3 The demonstratives

Borlish has four demonstratives, distinguishing proximal from distal and singular from plural. The proximal forms continue Latin *hoc* and *haec*,

Demonstratives		
	singular	plural
proximal	<i>oc</i> /ɔk/	<i>ec</i> /ɛk/
distal	<i>oç</i> /ɔts/	<i>eç</i> /ɛts/

the neuter singular and plural of *hic* ‘this’. The distal forms arose in late Old Borlish from *oc i* and *ec i*, with the adverb *i* ‘there’, since lost (Appendix B).

Demonstratives with the article

Used before a noun, a demonstrative normally follows the definite article. Since the demonstratives begin with a vowel, the article always has the form *l'*, or one of the fused forms of the previous section: *l'oc*, *dell'oc*, *all'oç*, *pall'eç*, *nossell'ec*.

- (67) *L'oc darfour quesq es tan quemant.*
 /lɔk dar'fur kwesk ɛz tan kwe'mant/
 def = prox.sg towel damson be so comfortable

‘This purple bathrobe is so comfy.’

- (68) *Vail l'oç quagl star y quagl pascent?*
 /vel lɔts kwejl star i kwejl 'pa.xnt/
 be.worth.sbjv def = dist.sg quail be.inf def curds eat-prs.ptcp

‘Should that quail be eating the curds?’

- (69) *Impar my fraðr j'am l'oç pascman a*
 /im'par mi 'fra.ðr ʒam lɔts 'pax'man a
 unlike 1sg.poss brother 1sg = like def = dist.sg restaurant at
manoscart.
 'ma.no'xart/
 hybrid

‘Unlike my brother I like that fusion restaurant.’

- (70) *Sceye all'oç asc pog avoccaçon a phasm.*
 /xi'je a'lɔts ax pɔj a.vɔ.ka'tsɔn a 'fazm/
 there.be-ipfv at.def = dist.sg age few entertainment at TV

‘There wasn’t much TV entertainment then.’

Demonstratives and number

Since number is not marked on the noun, the article combined with a demonstrative is the principal way of marking a definite noun phrase as singular or plural.

- (71) *L'oc* *scur pasc.*
 /ɒk xajr pax/
 def = prox.sg boy eat
 ‘This boy eats.’

- (72) *L'ec* *scur pascn.*
 /ɛk xajr 'pax.ɳ/
 def = prox.pl boy eat-3pl
 ‘These boys eat.’

In this role the deictic force of the demonstrative is often weak, and English may be better served by a plain definite.

- (73) *L'ec* *voç de nossy felau echovan tras*
 /ɛk vɔts de nɔ'si fe'lo ɛ.ko'van traz
 def = prox.pl voice of 1pl.poss mate resound-ipfv.3pl across
 y pereð.
 i pe'reθ/
 def bulkhead

‘Our mates’ voices carried through the partition.’

Where the deictic force is present, the plural distinguishes *l'ec* ‘these’ from *l'eç* ‘those’, just as the singular distinguishes *l'oc* ‘this’ from *l'oç* ‘that’.

- (74) *L'ec* *dougl nos mestein cascun.*
 /ɛk 'dujl nɔz mɛ'stin ka'xɪn/
 def = prox.pl bereavement 1pl sadden-3pl each.one
 ‘These losses sadden us all.’

- (75) *Jo vos lau ag treu dell'eç xiphar.*
 /ʒo vɔz lo ɛj traw dɛ'lɛts ksi'far/
 1sg 2pl praise to.def loyalty of.def = dist.pl henchman
 'I commend you on the loyalty of those henchmen.'

Demonstratives without the article

Without the article, the plural demonstratives mark an indefinite plural, corresponding to an English bare plural.

- (76) *Y belem ny forest se mis afaç con ec*
 /i be'lɛm ni fo'rɛst se mɪz a'fats kɔn ɛk
 def scene in.def forest refl put.pst forward with prox.pl
ciscr d'aucl.
tsɪxɾ do'tsɛl/
 squeal of = bird

'The forest scene opened with shrieks from birds.'

- (77) *Y regnanç er ec hom mixallant a casc*
 /i rij'nants ɛr ɛk ɔm ˌmɪ.ksa'lant a kax
 def regime cop.ipfv prox.pl person guillotine-prs.ptcp at each
jorn.
ʒɔrn/
 day

'The regime was beheading people every day.'

The bare demonstratives also appear in expressions of time, such as *oc aubon* 'this morning' and *oc annað* 'this year' (in the example above).

- (78) *Y ðocaç lour coy de dormir ec noit.*
 /i ðo'kats lur kɔj de dɔr'mɪr ɛk nɔjt/
 def trauma 3pl.obl stop from sleep-inf prox.pl night
 'The trauma keeps them up at night.'

- (79) *Attenað* *y* *zachet vel* *quaglar oç* *noit.*
 /a.te'naθ i za'ket vɛl kwɛj'lar ɔts nɔjt/
 wait-2pl.sbjv def glue will.sbjv set-inf dist.sg night
 'Wait for the glue to set overnight.'

Finally, the demonstratives can stand alone as pronouns. In a somewhat literary construction, the bare forms *oc*, *ec*, *oç* and *eç* are used as objects and placed before the verb, like the object clitics (Chapter 8).

- (80) *Da gent oc saun, y sar marcer dourra*
 /ða ʒɛnt ɔk son i sar mar'tser du'ra
 if people prox.sg know-3pl def net commercial hurt-fut
mal.
mal/
 badly
 'If people find out about this, the trade network will be affected badly.'

- (81) *L'arra oç saut ig caye sy*
 /la'ra ɔts sot aj kɛ'je si
 3sg.m=have.fut dist.sg know.pst.ptcp comp fall-ipfv 3sg.poss
mariðaç dovem nienter.
 ,ma.ri'ðats 'do.vɛm njen'tɛr/
 marriage second void
 'He must have known his second marriage was void.'

In ordinary usage the pronoun takes the article, and *l'oc* 'this (one)' and *l'oç* 'that (one)' behave like any other noun phrase.

- (82) *Jo so l'oc beint por my dolour*
 /ʒo so lək bint pər mi do'lur
 1sg be.1sg def = prox.sg drink.prs.ptcp for 1sg.poss pain
youdar.
 ju'dar/
 numb-inf

‘I’m drinking this to numb the pain.’

- (83) *Lodrignether l'oç no's meðes un pescot.*
 /loˌdraj.ne'θər lɔts nɔz me'ðɛz ɪn pe'xɔt/
 technically def = dist.sg neg = be even indf fish

‘Technically that’s not even a fish.’

The pronoun *l'oç* also heads free relative clauses, ‘what, that which’ (Chapter 22).

- (84) *Jo kiglau l'oç seyon rovað dec*
 /ʒo kaj'lo lɔts si'jɔn ro'vaθ dɛk
 1sg miss-pst def = dist.sg 3sg.agt ask-pst.ptcp because
j'er bucol hamtant.
 ʒər bi'kɔl ham'tant/
 1sg = cop.ipfv idyll dwell-prs.ptcp

‘I missed what he asked because I was daydreaming.’

The form *l'ig* /laj/ is not a demonstrative, though it looks like one. It is the form the complementiser *ig* ‘that’ takes after a word ending in a vowel sound (Chapter 21).

7.4 Quantifiers

Most quantifiers stand in place of the article rather than alongside it. *Casc* ‘each, every’ takes a bare noun; the corresponding pronoun is *cascun* ‘each one’ (as in the example above).

- (85) *Jamiscað plu, casc hom!*
 /ʒa.mi'xaθ pli kax ɔm/
 complain-2pl.sbjv no.more each person

‘Stop complaining, everyone!’

Toð ‘all, the whole’ is the exception: it is followed by the article (Section 7.1), or by a possessive, as in *toð mell'amig* ‘all my friends’. Without an article, *toð gent* means ‘everyone’.

- (86) *Toð gent saun ig cay ty morrig un sbayour*
 /təθ ʒɛnt son aj ke ti mɔ'raj in zbe'jur
 all people know-3pl comp fall 2sg.poss aunt indf gossip
jaçol.
 ʒa'tsɔl/
 longtime

‘Everyone knows your aunt’s an inveterate gossip.’

Pieç ‘some, a few’ takes a bare noun, but with the article it is partitive, ‘some of the’.

- (87) *Me stove pieç parol bisan dar a my*
 /me sto've pjets pa'rɔl bi'zan dar a mi
 1sg.obl must-ipfv some word crisp give.inf to 1sg.poss
fraðr.
 fraðr/
 brother

‘I had to tell my brother some hard truths.’

- (88) *Y nombler volau pieç y bors sdroyað par blisnot.*
 /i nɔm'blɛr vo'lo pjets i bɔrz zdrɔ'jaθ par bli'znɔt/
 def banker steal-pst some def fund store-pst.ptcp by eunuch

‘The banker stole some of the funds kept in escrow.’

Alcun ‘no, not any’ takes a bare noun; *alcun hom* is ‘nobody’.

- (89) *Y molin produg alcun zucar des insorgent lo*
 /i mo'lin pro'daj al'km zi'kar dez in.sɔr'gent lo
 def mill make no sugar since rebel 3sg.n.acc
quariçtovaurn.
kwa,ɾits.to'vɔɾɲ/
 sabotage-pst.3pl

‘The mill hasn’t produced any sugar since rebels sabotaged it.’

Pog ‘little, few’ and *tan* ‘so much, so many’ also take a bare noun (as in *pog avoccaçon* ‘not much entertainment’ above). Both double as degree words: *un pog* ‘a little, a bit’, *tan* ‘so’ (Chapter 23).

- (90) *Nos coum alant a haun posc tan semman.*
 /nɔz kum a'lant a hon pɔx tan sɛ'man/
 1pl get.pst-1pl landfall at haven after so.many week

‘We made landfall after so many weeks.’

The interrogative determiner *cal* ‘which, what’ likewise takes a bare noun, as in *cal praxitel* ‘which sculptor’ above.

Untal ‘such (a), some such, a kind of’ takes a bare noun, as in *untal jorn commovent* ‘such an active day’ and *ben untal pescot blanc* ‘or some such whitefish’. It is also used on its own as a pronoun, as in *untal vel jo mariðar* ‘such a man I would marry’.

- (91) *Ty fraðr es untal daugnam incaint sceir sy*
 /ti 'fra.ðɾ ez m'tal dog'nam m'kent xir si
 2sg.poss brother be such dupe prone there.be-inf 3sg.poss
lucr volar.
 'li.kɾ vo'lar/
 wealth steal-inf

‘Your brother’s the kind of dupe who’ll get his money stolen.’

Certan ‘some, certain’ takes a bare noun, as in *certan historicour* ‘some historians’, and is partitive ‘some of’ when followed by *de* or *entr*: *certan dell’ec method* ‘some of these methods’, *certan entr lou* ‘some of them’.

With the indefinite article it forms the specific indefinite *un certan* (Section 7.2).

- (92) *Certan dy niveu catr son y scaunç de melodram*
 /tser'tan di ni'vaw 'kat.ɾ sɔn i xonts de ˌme.lo'dram
 some of.def set four be.3pl def writing of musical
parsiscent.
 ˌpar.zi'xɛnt/
 study-prs.ptcp

‘Some in the fourth set are learning musical scriptwriting.’

The remaining quantifiers, *bempart* ‘many, lots of’, *necun* ‘neither, none’, *calscon* ‘any’ and *cuscon* ‘any, whoever’, likewise take a bare noun.

The one exception is *gran part* ‘most’, which is followed by *a* and a full noun phrase, definite or indefinite. The *a* fuses with the article in the usual way (*ag*, *all*’, *an*): *gran part ag dynasty imperial* ‘most of the imperial dynasty’, *gran part all’Emperour Drengoçan* ‘most of the Drengot emperors’.

7.5 Order of determiners

The determiners combine before the noun in a fixed order: first *toð* or a possessive, then the article, then a demonstrative, then a numeral. A possessive and the article appear together only before a vowel, where they fuse (*mell*’, *vossell*’). Adjectives normally follow the noun (Chapter 9).

<i>toð y cort</i>	‘the whole court’
<i>toð mell’amig</i>	‘all my friends’
<i>vossell’ec suggestion</i>	‘your suggestions’
<i>toll’eç xiphar</i>	‘all those henchmen’
<i>y dou tarnaç</i>	‘the two regulars’

Chapter 8

Pronouns

[To be written.]

Chapter 9

Adjectives

Borlish adjectives have two forms: a base form and a comparative form. The comparative is formed by adding a suffix, which shifts stress to the penultimate syllable.

9.1 Formation of the comparative

Regular comparatives in *-essem*

The regular comparative suffix is *-essem*, which replaces or follows the final segment of the adjective and attracts penultimate stress.

- (93) *leger* *legeressem*
 /le'ʒɛr le.ʒe're.sɛm/
 light lighter

Several orthographic adjustments may occur when the suffix is added. Before the vowel-initial suffix, < ç > becomes < c >, while < c > becomes < ch > to preserve the /k/ pronunciation.

- (94) *lavaç* *lavacessem* | *starc* *starchessem*
 /la'vats la.va'tsɛ.sɛm | stark star'ke.sɛm/
 wasteful more wasteful | strong stronger

After a final orthographic < -q >, a linking < -u- > is inserted.

- (95) *picq picquessem*
 /pɪk pɪ'kwɛ.sɛm/
 small smaller

The final consonant may be doubled in the comparative form to maintain the checked quality of the preceding vowel. This occurs most commonly with final < -l >.

- (96) *boncop boncoppessem*
 /bɔn'kɔp ɓɔn.kɔ'pɛ.sɛm/
 cheap cheaper

The final consonant may be voiced in the comparative form. This is seen most commonly in present participles ending in < -nt > (which form comparatives in < -ndessem >) and in adjectives ending in fricatives, though only final < -f > reflects this orthographically as < -vessem >.

- | | | | |
|------|-----------------------|--|-----------------------|
| (97) | <i>tart tardessem</i> | | <i>braf bravessem</i> |
| | /tart tar'dɛ.sɛm | | braf bra've.sɛm/ |
| | late later | | brave braver |

Adjectives ending in a written < -Vu > diphthong form the comparative in < -Vvessem >.

- (98) *blau blavessem*
 /blo bla've.sɛm/
 blue bluer

Certain historically long vowels in the final syllable of an adjective may shorten in the comparative form. This occurs most commonly with adjectives ending in *-ous*.

- (99) *fatuous fatuosessem*
 /fa'tjuz ɓa.tjo'zɛ.sɛm/
 clumsy clumsier

Adjectives ending in < -e > form the comparative in < -eyessem >.

- (100) *idone idoneyessem*
 /i.do'ne i.do.ni'jɛ.sɛm/
 suitable more suitable

Adjectives in syllabic -r

Adjectives ending in syllabic < -r > show several patterns. Occasionally they form regular comparatives in *-ressem*.

- (101) *jundr jundressem*
 /'ʒɪn.dr ʒɪn'drɛ.sɛm/
 junior more junior

Some adjectives, most notably those ending in the suffix *-abr* 'able', form comparatives in *-lessem* rather than *-ressem*.

- (102) *stabr stablessem | sengr senglessem*
 /'stab.r sta'blɛ.sɛm | 'sɛn.gr sɛn'glɛ.sɛm/
 steady steadier | simple simpler

The majority of adjectives ending in syllabic < -r > form the comparative with the suffix *-errem*, which replaces the final syllabic consonant and is stressed penultimately. The same adjustments that affect *-essem* may also affect *-errem*.

- (103) *nuvr nuverrem | diçr dicerrem*
 /'nɪv.r ni've.rɛm | 'dɪts.r di'tsɛ.rɛm/
 fresh fresher | great greater

- (104) *allagr allagherrem | leur leverrem*
 /a'lɛj.r a.lɛ'jɛ.rɛm | 'lau.r le've.rɛm/
 happy happier | free freer

Irregular comparatives

A few adjectives show irregular stem changes in the comparative.

- (105) *brey bressem*
 /bri 'brɛ.sɛm/
 short shorter

Several common adjectives have fully suppletive comparative forms.

- | | | | | | |
|-------|------------------|--|-------------------|--|---------------------|
| (106) | <i>bon ottem</i> | | <i>mal pessem</i> | | <i>gran maissem</i> |
| | /bɔn 'ɔ.tɛm | | mal 'pɛ.sɛm | | gran 'mɛ.sɛm/ |
| | good better | | bad worse | | big bigger |

Chapter 10

Numerals

[To be written.]

Part IV

Verbs

Chapter 11

Verb Morphology

[To be written.]

Chapter 12

Tense, Aspect and Mood

[To be written.]

Chapter 13

Copulas, Auxiliaries and Modal Verbs

[To be written.]

Chapter 14

Voice and Valency

[To be written.]

Part V

Adverbs and Function Words

Chapter 15

Adverbs

[To be written.]

Chapter 16

Prepositions

[To be written.]

Chapter 17

Conjunctions, Particles and Interjections

[To be written.]

Part VI

Clauses and Sentences

Chapter 18

The Simple Clause

[To be written.]

Chapter 19

Negation

[To be written.]

Chapter 20

Questions, Commands and Exclamations

[To be written.]

Chapter 21

Coordination and Subordination

[To be written.]

Chapter 22

Relative Clauses

[To be written.]

Chapter 23

Comparison

[To be written.]

Chapter 24

Information Structure

[To be written.]

Part VII

Words and Usage

Chapter 25

Word Formation

[To be written.]

Chapter 26

Lexical Fields

[To be written.]

Chapter 27

Register, Address and Names

[To be written.]

Appendices

Appendix A

Verb Tables

[To be written.]

Appendix B

From Vulgar Latin to Borlish

[To be written.]

Appendix C

Basic Vocabulary

[To be written.]

Appendix D

Glossed Texts

[To be written.]